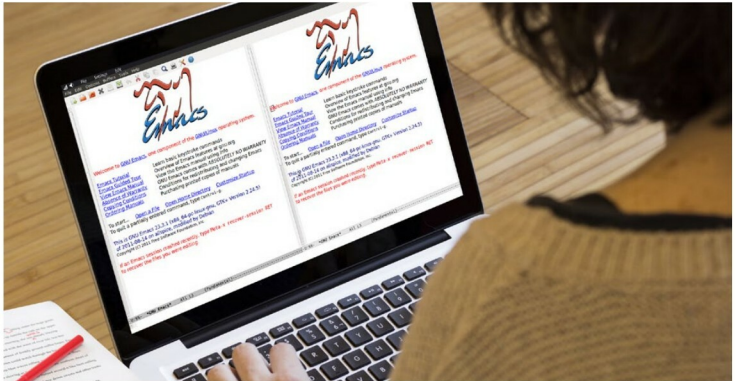


An Introduction to GNU Emacs

GNU Emacs, created by Richard Stallman, is an extensible, customisable text editor. While Emacs has many variants, GNU Emacs is the most widely used. This article spawns a series on learning to use it.



GNU Emacs is a very popular text editor written in C and Emacs Lisp. It can be run on many platforms, and can be easily customised and extended for user needs. It was created by Richard Stallman, the founder of the GNU project. This article is the first in a series on how to use it. There are a number of tutorials available for GNU Emacs; this series of articles provides one approach to understanding and learning the software. You are encouraged to refer to the official GNU Emacs reference manual for more information, and it supersedes everything.

Here are a few interesting quotes on Emacs.

"I use Emacs, which might be thought of as a thermonuclear word processor." - Neal Stephenson (from *'In the Beginning... Was the Command Line'*)

"Emacs is undoubtedly the most powerful programmer's editor in existence. It's a big, feature-laden program with a great deal of flexibility and customisability. ... Emacs has an entire programming language inside it that can be used to write arbitrarily powerful editor functions." - Eric S. Raymond (from *'The Art of UNIX Programming'*)

"Personally, I feel inspired whenever I open Emacs. Like a craftsman entering his workshop, I feel a realm of possibility open before me. I feel the comfort of an environment that has evolved over time to fit me perfectly - an assortment of packages and keybindings which help me

bring ideas to life day after day." - Daniel Higginbotham (in *'Clojure for the Brave and True'*)

"Emacs could not have been reached by a process of careful design, because such processes arrive only at goals which are visible at the outset, and whose desirability is established on the bottom line at the outset. Neither I nor anyone else visualised an extensible editor until I had made one, nor appreciated its value until he had experienced it. EMACS exists because I felt free to make individually useful small improvements on a path whose end was not in sight." - Richard Stallman

Installation

You can use your favourite GNU/Linux distribution package manager to install GNU Emacs. On Debian/Ubuntu, you can install it with the following command:

```
$ sudo apt-get install emacs
```

On Fedora, you can use the Yum package manager as shown below:

```
$ sudo yum install emacs
```

The *emerge* tool can install GNU Emacs on Gentoo, as follows: